

“I can’t ask our American soldiers out there to **continue to fight** with **one hand tied** behind their backs.”

PRESIDENT JOHNSON TO HIS ADVISERS, FEBRUARY 1965

» AFTER

Although it caused tens of thousands of civilian deaths, Rolling Thunder failed to damage North Vietnam sufficiently to trigger meaningful negotiations.

POLITICAL PLOY

The **halt to Rolling Thunder** just prior to the 1968 presidential election was called by Johnson to encourage votes for fellow Democrat Hubert Humphrey. The strategy **failed** to win the election, which went to the Republican candidate.

VICTORY FOR PEACE

Richard Nixon won the presidency in 1968 by promising “peace with honor.” Following the election, North Vietnam enjoyed a respite from bombing until President Nixon authorized **further punishing airstrikes**, initially in response to the 1972 Easter Offensive, and subsequently to bring the North Vietnamese back to the **negotiating table**.